The first game of the tour was in New Plymouth and the ground was surrounded by hills. It was as if a stadium had been planted in the middle of mountains and Bishan Singh Bedi, our manager, decided to make the most of the conditions. Bedi, one of the best left-arm spinners of all time, was a really hard taskmaster and liked to make us run huge distances to improve our fitness. At New Plymouth our fitness drills involved running in the mountains and by the end of the training sessions we had absolutely no energy left.

As in Pakistan, I did not start particularly well and in the first Test at Christchurch, which started on 2 February, I was dismissed by Danny Morrison for a golden duck. It was a good delivery but the send-off was interesting, to say the least. I could hear most of the New Zealand players calling me a schoolboy, with plenty of F-words thrown in. They kindly advised me to go back to playing cricket with my school chums, suggesting that I wasn't fit to compete at international level. I kept my mouth shut.

The second innings was an improvement in that I managed to stay at the wicket for close to an hour, playing forty-four balls. My 24 runs were enough to give me confidence that I was capable of holding my own in strange conditions. Although I had fallen to John Bracewell, trying to cut a ball close to my body, I had successfully negotiated Richard Hadlee, which I counted as an achievement. Hadlee's first two deliveries to me were bouncers, but each was profoundly different from the other. The first was an outswinging bouncer that went away after pitching; the second came in from the same spot and I had to keep my eye on the ball till the last moment to get my head out of the way. Such was the ability of the man that you had to be at your best at all times to keep him at bay.

New Zealand won the first Test by ten wickets and the second Test match at Napier started only a few days later, on 9 February. We decided to bat first after winning the toss but the first day was completely washed out by rain. The match finally started on the second day and I was unbeaten on 80 by the end of the third day's play. The ball was doing a little and batting wasn't particularly easy, but not once did I try to dominate the bowling the way I had in domestic cricket.

When I went in to bat on the fourth morning the possibility of a hundred was on my mind. I was just 20 runs short and was determined to take my opportunity. I started well and hit the very first Danny Morrison delivery for four. For the rest of the over he bowled short and I was